Chapter 5 · Story

Everyone says yes. Has everyone agreed?

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The quiet vote · c05s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

What could reveal concerns before discussion?

A Have the chair announce the preferred answer.

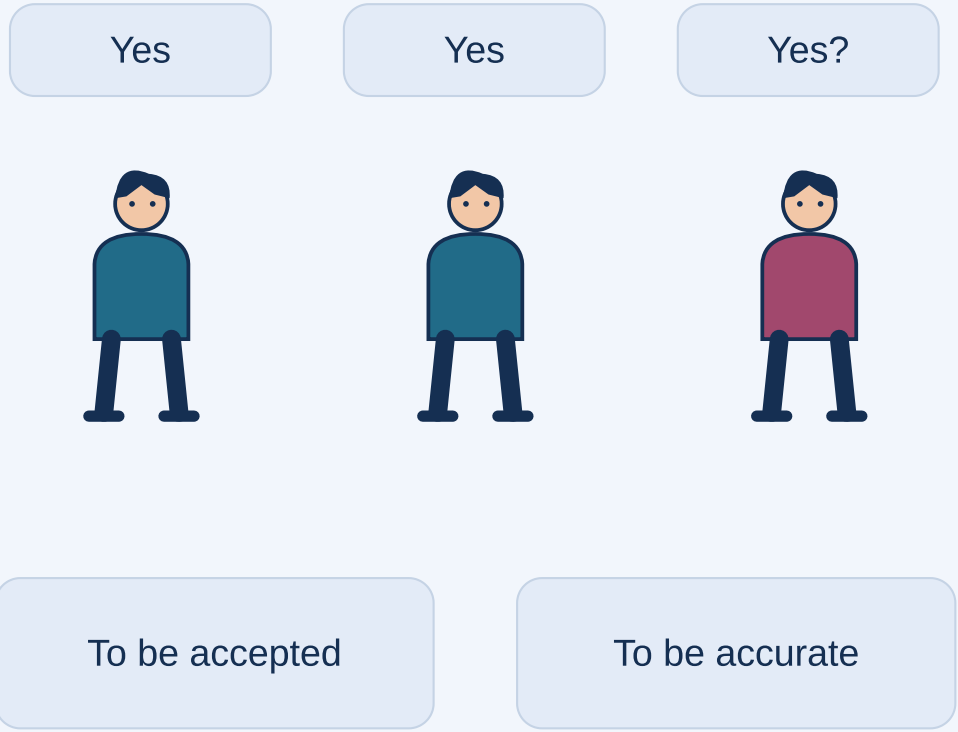
B Collect independent written judgments first.

C Ask only experienced members to speak.

Suggested answer: B. Independent written judgments let people record a view before seeing which answer has public support.

Two reasons to follow a group.

- Informational: they may know better.
- Normative: I want acceptance.
- Public agreement can differ from private belief.

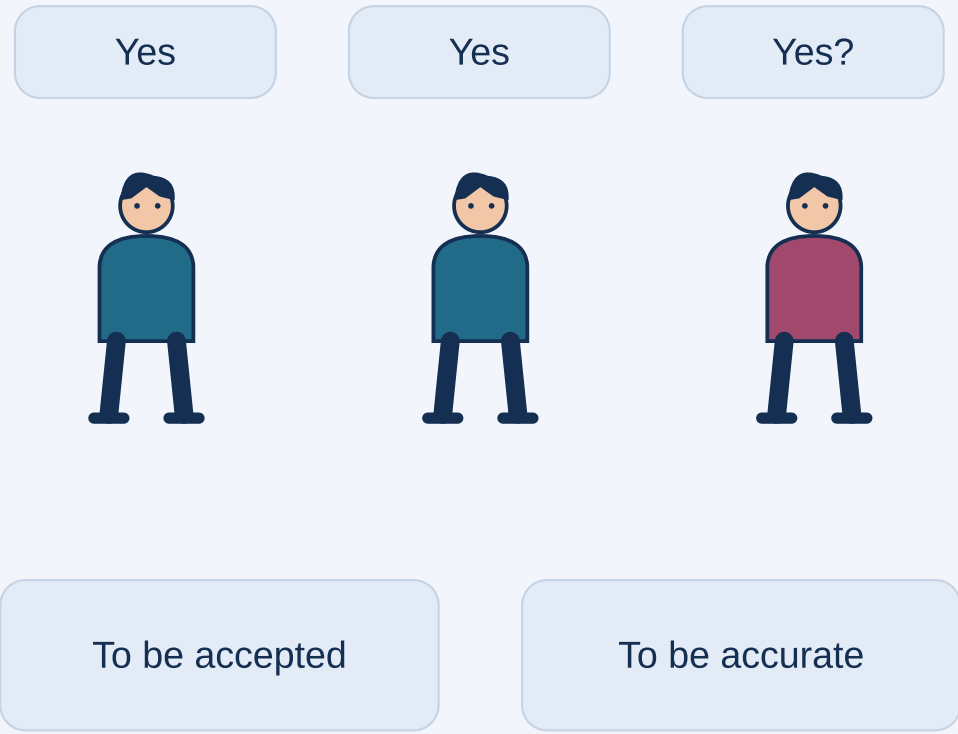


The same answer can have different motives.

Public agreement can reflect acceptance or information.

Authority changes the pressure.

- Compliance: responding to a request.
- Obedience: responding to an authority’s order.
- Make stopping and questioning possible.

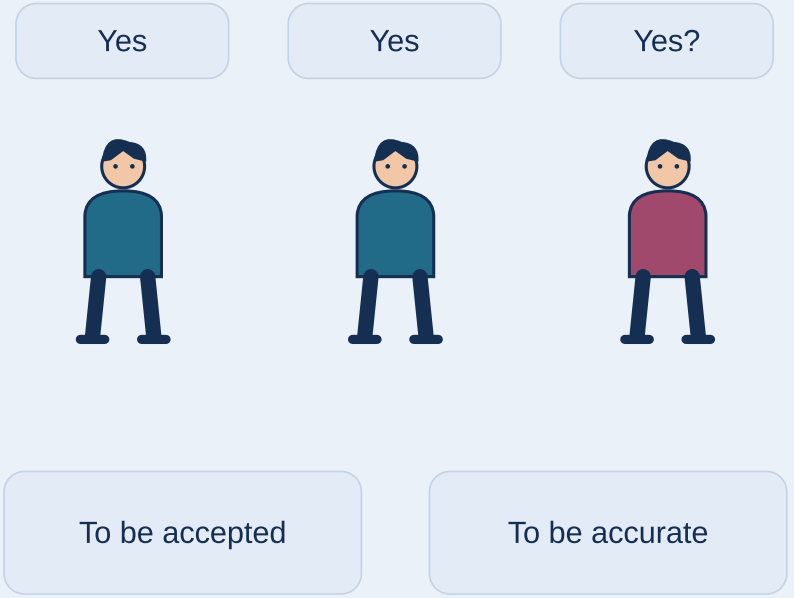


The same answer can have different motives.

Public agreement can reflect acceptance or information.

What can we really conclude?

In Asch’s line-judgment studies, participants compared line lengths after hearing a group give incorrect answers. The studies examined when people would follow a majority despite the visible evidence. In Milgram’s studies, an experimenter urged participants to continue a task they believed delivered electric shocks to another person. The studies examined responses to apparent authority in a highly structured setting. Both sets of studies raise questions about methods, ethics, and how widely their findings apply. Their results concern particular conditions of influence; they are not universal obedience rates. Some participants resisted, and responses varied with the conditions. Harmful conduct is not inevitable.



The same answer can have different motives.

Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

The chair requests bypassing a required check. Which process helps?

A Let the first confident person decide.

B Allow anonymous complaints afterward.

C Pause and use an agreed safety escalation route.

Suggested answer: C. An agreed stop-and-escalation route makes questioning possible while the safety decision still matters.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Distinguish normative and informational influence.

> Why can public agreement overstate private agreement?

1. Normative influence concerns acceptance. Informational influence treats other people’s responses as evidence.

2. Public agreement can hide private doubt when people copy early answers, suppress concerns, or assume that others have checked.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

For an agreed, low-stakes group choice, have everyone write a view before discussion. Compare the range of initial reasons with what a show of hands might have revealed.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.